

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Repair That Actually Works

(A Strand Chapter – listen carefully.)

Hi, friend. J.A.R. again.

This chapter is about how to make a repair that actually repairs. Most kids – and most adults – have been taught an idea of how to apologize that does not actually work. The idea is: you say sorry. You hug. You move on.

That is not a repair. That is a gesture.

A real repair has steps. The steps are real. They take a little longer than the gesture. They also work in a way the gesture does not.

I want to give you the steps now, in plain language, because you are going to need them. Most kids will need to repair something this month. Some of you will need to repair something today. Real life is full of small repairs. The skill of repairing well – the skill of being a good repairer – is one of the most valuable skills a person can have. Adults who can repair well have better marriages, better friendships, better jobs, and better kids. Adults who cannot repair are stuck in the same fights for decades.

You are going to learn this now. While you are nine.

Here are the steps.

STEP ONE – NAME WHAT YOU DID.

In plain language. Out loud. To the person you hurt.

Not I'm sorry if you were upset. Not I'm sorry you took it that way. Not I'm sorry but – (do not start an apology with I'm sorry but. The but erases the apology.)

You say: *I am sorry that I – and then the verb. I am sorry that I lied to you. I am sorry that I said an unkind thing. I am sorry that I broke your toy. I am sorry that I did not stand up for you.*

The naming is the taking responsibility. If you cannot name it, you have not taken responsibility yet.

STEP TWO — NAME THE IMPACT.

What did your action do to the other person? You do not get to decide this. You ask them, or you guess carefully.

That must have been embarrassing in front of everyone. That probably made you feel like you couldn't trust me. That probably hurt your feelings. I imagine you felt left out.

Naming the impact tells the person *I see what I did. I understand how it landed. I am not minimizing.*

STEP THREE — DO NOT MAKE EXCUSES.

Even if you have a reason — and you probably do — do not, in the same sentence as the apology, explain why you did it. The explanation, in the middle of the apology, sounds like an excuse, even if it isn't. Save the explanation for later, when the apology has done its work. If the person wants to hear why, they will ask. Then you tell them.

STEP FOUR — NAME WHAT WILL CHANGE.

This is the most important step. An apology without a next time is just words. An apology with a next time is a promise.

Next time, when I am frustrated, I am going to take a breath instead of yelling. Next time, when I do not know an answer, I am going to ask, not make something up. Next time, when somebody is mean to a friend in front of me, I am going to say something.

The change is what makes the apology trustworthy. Without the change, the same thing will happen again, and the apology was just air.

STEP FIVE — ASK IF THERE IS ANYTHING YOU CAN DO TO MAKE IT BETTER.

Sometimes there is. *Can I help you fix the toy? Can I tell the other kids you didn't actually say what they thought you said? Can I write a note to your teacher?*

Sometimes there isn't. *Is there anything I can do? — No, I just needed you to hear me.*

Either way, asking is part of the repair. It tells the person *you matter to me. I want this to be okay between us.*

STEP SIX — GIVE THEM TIME.

After the repair, the person you hurt might still be sad. They might still be a little distant. They might need some time before things feel normal again.

That is okay. The repair is not magic. The repair starts the healing. The healing takes time.

You do not get to demand they forgive you on a schedule. You let them have their feelings on their own time. You show up consistently. You change your behavior. You let the new behavior speak louder than the apology.

This is, in fact, the most important part of repair. Words tell people what you mean. Behavior tells people who you are. If your apology is followed by the same behavior again, the apology becomes meaningless. If your apology is followed by changed behavior — over months, over years — the apology grows. It becomes more believable over time, not less.

That is what real repair looks like.

It is slower than the gesture-apology. It is also realer.

You are going to need this skill many times in your life. Practice it now. The first time you really do it — the first time

you sit a friend down and name what you did and name the impact and name what will change — you will feel, in your chest, the difference between a gesture-apology and a real one.

A real one cleans something. The gesture-apology does not.

You will know the feeling. After you feel it once, you will not want to do the gesture-apology again.

That is what this strand chapter is for. To teach you the steps once, in a quiet voice, so you can use them for the rest of your life.

Okay. End of strand chapter. Back to the kids.

— J.A.R.